

The messaging system varies greatly from one set to another. While messaging is pure fun on some phones, it can be a really miserable experience on others. Predictive text input, or T9, plays a big role in the messaging experience of a phone.

Motorola and BenQ phones use the iTap method of input, where you have to hit enter after typing each and every word. Obviously this is a cumbersome process, and Nokia, Samsung and LG have a much more user-friendly technique.

The messaging system on Nokia phones is not just extremely easy to use, but also a pleasurable experience. On these sets, the predictive input works perfectly, and the interface is intuitive enough to predict the word correctly at the first go. Samsung and LG, instead of reinventing the wheel, took a feather off the Finnish maker and introduced its messaging system in their own models.

The SGH-X430 and SGH-S500 from Samsung, and LG G3100 and G7030, have a wonderful messaging system that is very simple to use. Since most Korean sets are flip phones, they have a well spaced keypad layout that comes in handy when typing a message. Another thing about the flip phones is that the colour screens are large, and can easily display four lines of text. In fact, Samsung is way ahead of the others, as the fonts on the Samsung screen are large and exceptionally clear.

On the Bird S1190, the fonts are way too small. Even the keypad is not comfortable to type messages with. The 9@9++ from Philips has a messaging interface that can be described as decent and usable. There's no doubt about the fact that messaging is easy with the Nokia 2300, but does take a while to get used to the wacky keypad.

Sagem's My X-2 offers a good interface, but a major glitch is that the rubber keys lack tactile feedback. Thankfully, the other two models from Sagem don't have this problem.

The Onetouch 535 from Alcatel has great buttons, but the messaging system on this model is a complete let down. Blame this on the poor accuracy of its predictive input method.

The BenQ M555C's cumbersome iTap method is painful to use, despite having a decent interface.

Panasonic pays the price for its small buttons heavily. The keys on its model—the EB-G51—don't have markings on them. Instead, they are printed on the body itself. As a result, the backlight pretty much does not serve its purpose when it comes to typing in the dark.

Barring the Philips Xenium 9@9++, all the other cell phones in

this category have polyphonic ringtones. The higher-end phones—the Samsung, LG and Pantech models—have the luxury of loading melodies using the sync software. On the rest, you can download ringtones via GPRS.

Coming to personal information management (PIM), the higher-end phones have the right variety and number of features. The PIM functions are much better than those on basic phones. But these functions are way behind smart phones or, for that matter, PDA phones. The Samsung, Pantech and some of the phones from LG have a useful calendar option. This feature entails scheduling and fields for events. In addition to that, these handsets also feature 'To do' lists, reminders and alarms.

Samsung offers almost 9 MB of memory on its cell phone. This memory is shared for messages, events and PIM functions. Alcatel's Onetouch 535 also boasts of a decent PIM. The M555C from BenQ closely follows the high end phones, if the handful of features it packs are any indication.

The Philips 9@9++ comes with one of the best PIM features. The My X-2 and My X-5 from Sagem are quite disappointing, as they don't have proper PIM functions. The Siemens A60 has exactly the same problem.

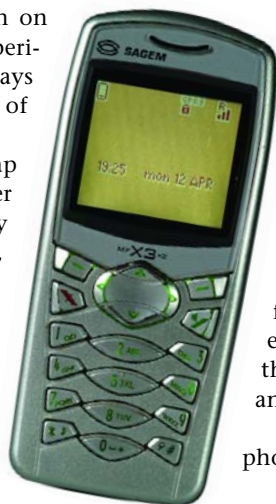
Sadly, connectivity options are quite limited in these mid-range phones. Most have infrared connectivity or serial connectivity. Samsung's S500, LG's G7030 and the Pantech G300, are all infrared enabled.

Except for the Nokia 2300, all the other handsets in this category are WAP-enabled. GPRS is also a common feature with most of the phones, except for the Bird and Nokia sets.

The Nokia 2300 and Philips 630, both boast of an FM receiver that allows you to tune into radio stations. Even headsets are bundled with these two models, so you can tune in to your favourite radio stations immediately. The Nokia model also allows you to listen to the radio using the handsfree speaker. All you need to do is to plug in the headset.

With the scrutiny over, two phones emerge as the contenders for the winner's tag. Both the Samsung SGH-S500 and the Pantech G300 stand out as the cell phones with the right balance of cool features and exceptional performance. And both these models are on par in the race for the perfect cell phone.

Of course, there are a few differences. While Pantech boasts of a 270K colour screen, the Samsung model dons a 65K colour screen. And when it comes to better ergonomics, wonderful keypad layout, exquisite display screen and smooth signal reception, the Samsung S500 definitely edges past the Pantech G300. We recommend both phones, the final choice is yours!



Sagem MyX-3-2
Rating: B
Price: Rs 6,199



Philips 630
Rating: B-
Price: Rs 8,890



Pantech G300
Rating: C-
Price: Rs 13,995